

2. Two teams to be seeded based on the FIFA/Coca-Cola Men's World Ranking. The two seeded teams will play for a FIFA World Cup 26 slot against the winners of the first two play-off matches involving the four unseeded teams.

On 14 February 2023, the FIFA Council approved the hosts of the FIFA World Cup 26, namely Canada, Mexico and the USA, to qualify automatically for the final competition, with their slots therefore being deducted from the overall allocation of six assigned to Concacaf.

ARTICLE 12: GROUP AND KNOCKOUT STAGES

- 12.1 The format of the final competition consists of a group stage, followed by the knockout stages with a round of 32, a round of 16, quarter-finals, semi-finals, the match for third place and the final.
- 12.2 The 48 teams taking part in the final competition will be divided into 12 groups of four teams.
- 12.3 FIFA will seed the teams for the Final Draw for the FIFA World Cup 26™ in accordance with the teams' ranking within the FIFA/Coca-Cola Men's World Ranking, as established in the draw procedures. FIFA will divide the teams into groups by seeding and drawing lots in public, taking into account geographical and sporting considerations.

As the host countries, Canada, Mexico and the USA will be assigned to the following positions: A1 for Mexico, B1 for Canada and D1 for the USA, as per the match schedule released on 4 February 2024 and as applied in the draw procedures.

The teams in the 12 groups will be designated as follows:

Group A	Group B	Group C	Group D	Group E	Group F
A1 (Mexico)	B1 (Canada)	C1	D1 (USA)	E1	F1
A2	B2	C2	D2	E2	F2
A3	B3	C3	D3	E3	F3
A4	B4	C4	D4	E4	F4



Group G	Group H	Group I	Group J	Group K	Group L
G1	H1	I1	J1	K1	L1
G2	H2	I2	J2	K2	L2
G3	H3	I3	J3	K3	L3
G4	H4	I4	J4	K4	L4

12.4 The group matches will be played following the schedule below. Each team plays each of the other teams in the same group once, according to a league system with three points for a win, one point for a draw and no points for a defeat.

MATCH DAY 1	MATCH DAY 2	MATCH DAY 3
A1 v. A2 A3 v. A4	A1 v. A3 A4 v. A2	A4 v. A1 A2 v. A3
B1 v. B2 B3 v. B4	B1 v. B3 B4 v. B2	B4 v. B1 B2 v. B3
C1 v. C2 C3 v. C4	C1 v. C3 C4 v. C2	C4 v. C1 C2 v. C3
D1 v. D2 D3 v. D4	D1 v. D3 D4 v. D2	D4 v. D1 D2 v. D3
E1 v. E2 E3 v. E4	E1 v. E3 E4 v. E2	E4 v. E1 E2 v. E3
F1 v. F2 F3 v. F4	F1 v. F3 F4 v. F2	F4 v. F1 F2 v. F3
G1 v. G2 G3 v. G4	G1 v. G3 G4 v. G2	G4 v. G1 G2 v. G3
H1 v. H2 H3 v. H4	H1 v. H3 H4 v. H2	H4 v. H1 H2 v. H3
I1 v. I2 I3 v. I4	I1 v. I3 I4 v. I2	I4 v. I1 I2 v. I3
J1 v. J2 J3 v. J4	J1 v. J3 J4 v. J2	J4 v. J1 J2 v. J3
K1 v. K2 K3 v. K4	K1 v. K3 K4 v. K2	K4 v. K1 K2 v. K3
L1 v. L2 L3 v. L4	L1 v. L3 L4 v. L2	L4 v. L1 L2 v. L3

Note: the above configuration does not necessarily represent the chronological order in which the matches will be played.

The last two matches in each group shall have simultaneous kick-off times on the same day, unless stipulated otherwise by FIFA (e.g. in cases of force majeure).

- 12.5 The 12 teams finishing first and second in each group as well as the eight best teams among those finishing third will qualify for the round of 32.
- 12.6 The 32 teams that qualify from the group stage will contest the round of 32 as follows:

Match no.	Team A	v.	Team B	Winner
(1) M73	Runner-up A (2A)	v.	Runner-up B (2B)	= Winner (1) M73 (W73)
(2) M74	Winner E (1E)	v.	Best 3 rd place of ABCDF	= Winner (2) M74 (W74)
(3) M75	Winner F (1F)	v.	Runner-up C (2C)	= Winner (3) M75 (W75)
(4) M76	Winner C (1C)	v.	Runner-up F (2F)	= Winner (4) M76 (W76)
(5) M77	Winner I (1I)	v.	Best 3 rd place of CDFGH	= Winner (5) M77 (W77)
(6) M78	Runner-up E (2E)	v.	Runner-up I (2I)	= Winner (6) M78 (W78)
(7) M79	Winner A (1A)	v.	Best 3 rd place of CEFHI	= Winner (7) M79 (W79)
(8) M80	Winner L (1L)	v.	Best 3 rd place of EHJK	= Winner (8) M80 (W80)
(9) M81	Winner D (1D)	v.	Best 3 rd place of BEFIJ	= Winner (9) M81 (W81)
(10) M82	Winner G (1G)	v.	Best 3 rd place of AEHIJ	= Winner (10) M82 (W82)
(11) M83	Runner-up K (2K)	v.	Runner-up L (2L)	= Winner (11) M83 (W83)
(12) M84	Winner H (1H)	v.	Runner-up J (2J)	= Winner (12) M84 (W84)
(13) M85	Winner B (1B)	v.	Best 3 rd place of EFGIJ	= Winner (13) M85 (W85)
(14) M86	Winner J (1J)	v.	Runner-up H (2H)	= Winner (14) M86 (W86)
(15) M87	Winner K (1K)	v.	Best 3 rd place of DEIJL	= Winner (15) M87 (W87)
(16) M88	Runner-up D (2D)	v.	Runner-up G (2G)	= Winner (16) M88 (W88)

Note: the above configuration of matches for the round of 32 does not necessarily represent the chronological order in which the matches will be played as teams from the same group shall not meet each other in the round of 32.



Annexe C of these Regulations includes the 495 different possible combinations of the eight best-ranked third-placed teams and their next match-up for the round of 32, at the completion of the group stage.

12.7 The 16 teams that qualify from the round of 32 will contest the round of 16 as follows:

Match no.	Team A	v.	Team B	Winner
(17) M89	(2) Winner M74 (W74)	v.	(5) Winner M77 (W77)	= Winner (17) M89 (W89)
(18) M90	(1) Winner M73 (W73)	v.	(3) Winner M75 (W75)	= Winner (18) M90 (W90)
(19) M91	(4) Winner M76 (W76)	v.	(6) Winner M78 (W78)	= Winner (19) M91 (W91)
(20) M92	(7) Winner M79 (W79)	v.	(8) Winner M80 (W80)	= Winner (20) M92 (W92)
(21) M93	(11) Winner M83 (W83)	v.	(12) Winner M84 (W84)	= Winner (21) M93 (W93)
(22) M94	(9) Winner M81 (W81)	v.	(10) Winner M82 (W82)	= Winner (22) M94 (W94)
(23) M95	(14) Winner M86 (W86)	v.	(16) Winner M88 (W88)	= Winner (23) M95 (W95)
(24) M96	(13) Winner M85 (W85)	v.	(15) Winner M87 (W87)	= Winner (24) M96 (W96)

Note: the above configuration does not necessarily represent the chronological order in which the matches will be played.

12.8 The eight teams that qualify from the round of 16 will contest the quarter-finals as follows:

Match no.	Team A	v.	Team B	Winner
(A) M97	(17) Winner M89	v.	(18) Winner M90	= Winner (A) M97 (W97)
(B) M98	(21) Winner M93	v.	(22) Winner M94	= Winner (B) M98 (W98)
(C) M99	(19) Winner M91	v.	(20) Winner M92	= Winner (C) M99 (W99)
(D) M100	(23) Winner M95	v.	(24) Winner M96	= Winner (D) M100 (W100)

Note: the above configuration does not necessarily represent the chronological order in which the matches will be played.

12.9 The four winners of the quarter-finals will contest the semi-finals as follows:

Match no.	Team A	v.	Team B	Winner
(SF1) M101	(A) Winner M97	v.	(B) Winner M98	= Winner SF1 (W101)
(SF2) M102	(C) Winner M99	v.	(D) Winner M100	= Winner SF2 (W102)

Note: the above configuration does not necessarily represent the chronological order in which the matches will be played.

12.10 The two runners-up of the semi-finals will contest the play-off for third place, as follows:

Match no.	Team A	v.	Team B	Winner
M103	Runner-up SF1 (M101)	v.	Runner-up SF2 (M102)	= Winner M103 Winner of play-off for third place

12.11 The two winners of the semi-finals will contest the final, as follows:

Match no.	Team A	v.	Team B	Winner
M104 (Final)	Winner SF1 (W101)	v.	Winner SF2 (W102)	= Winner M104 FIFA World Cup 26 champions

